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UK Visa Status: Student Visa. Eligible for Graduate Visa (2 Years Full Working Rights)

17 October 2026

Hiring Team
FDM Group

Application: Graduate AI Engineer (London)

Dear FDM hiring team,

I am applying for the Graduate AI Engineer role in your Agentic Engineering and Build Capability CoE. Your posting says you will spend more time on what a graduate built and why than on their degree, so I have led with working systems. Over three years at HDFC Asset Management I designed and shipped LLM applications, agentic tool-calling workflows and RAG services used by the Compliance, Client Service and Investment teams, then changed them based on what those users found.

At HDFC I started from what each department needed to get done and worked with its staff to define what the tool had to do. I then built it end to end: a ReactJS frontend, Python FastAPI microservices in Docker, deployed on AWS through a one-click Jenkins and GitLab CI/CD pipeline. The RAG system used LlamaIndex with Azure OpenAI and a separate pgvector database per department, and agents called Python functions as tools to run SQL-backed fund comparisons. A Python pipeline that parsed over 300 rating-agency emails a day saved 60 analyst hours a month, and when one agency began sending its emails as images I replaced AWS Textract with Azure OpenAI to keep it working.

The governance and cost side of your role is work I have done in practice. Each department's documents sat in a separate vector database, users were authenticated against the company LDAP server with role-based access, prompt changes were versioned in Git, and the Compliance department reviewed the applications. An Nginx reverse proxy was one of the fixes that took them through the security team's VAPT. On cost, Llama-3 self-hosted on a GPU instance served the largest department, and the stronger Azure OpenAI outputs went to decision makers. In my own project Wingman, rate limits led me to evaluate 12 archetypes instead of 108 personas, cache by input hash, and validate model output with Pydantic rather than trust it.

I also work with AI as part of my own workflow. I placed 2nd at the Encode Vibe Coding Hackathon (Codeplain track) with Wingman.ai, built with codeplain's spec-driven framework, and I use Claude Code. For my MSc dissertation with AstraZeneca I co-built CellLineSelector, a scoring and ranking tool with a RAG assistant; my focus was the data preprocessing, the scoring algorithm and the RAG layer, and feedback from AstraZeneca scientists shaped it.

I want to be direct about where I am earlier in my development. At HDFC I did not use evaluation harnesses, golden datasets or LLM-as-judge tooling: quality came from user feedback, system-prompt guardrails and Compliance review. My metric-based evaluation is from academic work (VisionCaptioner, scored with SBERT cosine similarity, BLEU and ROUGE-L over five seeds). I have not practised AI FinOps formally, and I have not worked in a formally run Agile client squad. Building a habit of evaluating against defined success criteria on top of what I have already shipped is what I would most like this programme to give me.

In my final year I acted as de facto team lead for up to four interns, and two of my projects were recognised as Best Team Project (2024, 2025). I am currently in Bristol finishing my MSc in Data Science (result awaited), hold a Student Visa and am eligible for the Graduate Visa, which gives two years of full working rights in the UK. The role is based in London and I would be glad to discuss arrangements. Thank you for considering my application; I would be glad to talk it through.

Yours sincerely,
Kaustubh Sonawane